

Psalms 99

Holy Is He

Let them praise thy great and terrible name: for it is holy
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The LORD reigneth; let the people tremble: he sitteth between the cherubims; let the earth be moved.*
- 2 *The LORD is great in Zion; and he is high above all the people.*
- 3 *Let them praise thy great and terrible name; for it is holy.*
- 4 *The king's strength also loveth judgment; thou dost establish equity, thou executest judgment and righteousness in Jacob.*
- 5 *Exalt ye the LORD our God, and worship at his footstool; for he is holy.*
- 6 *Moses and Aaron among his priests, and Samuel among them that call upon his name; they called upon the LORD, and he answered them.*
- 7 *He spake unto them in the cloudy pillar: they kept his testimonies, and the ordinance that he gave them.*
- 8 *Thou answeredst them, O LORD our God: thou wast a God that forgavest them, though thou tookest vengeance of their inventions.*
- 9 *Exalt the LORD our God, and worship at his holy hill; for the LORD our God is holy.*

2 • CONTEXT

Psalm 99 is structured around a threefold refrain—'holy is he'—each time following a description of God's kingship, justice, and covenant faithfulness to those who called on Him, including Moses, Aaron, and Samuel by name. Henry treats the refrain's repetition as deliberate emphasis: holiness is not one attribute among many but the psalm's central, load-bearing claim about who God is and how He must be approached.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The Lord's reign is announced as cause for trembling among the peoples; enthroned between the cherubim, the earth itself is moved. His greatness is celebrated as exalted above all people, and the refrain lands for the first time: let them praise His great and terrible name, for it is holy.

Verse 4-5

The king's strength is explicitly tied to justice: He loves judgment, has established equity, and has executed judgment and righteousness in Jacob. The appropriate response follows directly—exalt the Lord, worship at His footstool—closed again by the refrain: for He is holy.

Verse 6-9

Specific figures are named as examples of intercessors who called on God and were answered: Moses and Aaron among His priests, Samuel among those who called on His name. God spoke to them in the cloudy pillar, and they kept His testimonies and the ordinance He gave. Even while forgiving, He is described as taking vengeance on their inventions—mercy and justice held together, not traded off. The psalm closes exalting the Lord and worshiping at His holy hill, once more because He is holy.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Holiness is not an isolated attribute alongside God's power and mercy but the defining reality that shapes how both must be understood—His strength expresses itself in love of justice, and His mercy toward those who call on Him never comes at the expense of righteousness. The repeated refrain insists that this holiness, not merely God's power or kindness, is the ultimate reason worship is due.

Application for life today.

Let this psalm's repeated refrain reshape how you think about God's holiness—not as a distant, forbidding quality but as the very ground of the justice and mercy you depend on. Consider Moses, Aaron, and Samuel's example: they are remembered specifically as people who called on God and kept His testimonies, not merely as figures of renown; let that shape what you actually ask for and how faithfully you respond. Notice how mercy and justice are held together, not traded off, in verse 8—resist any theology that treats God's forgiveness as indifference to sin.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does the psalm's repeated insistence that God 'is holy' (vv. 3, 5, 9) reshape your understanding of His power and mercy as connected rather than separate?

2. What would it mean to follow Moses, Aaron, and Samuel's example (vv. 6–7)—not just admiring their history, but actually calling on God and keeping His testimonies?

3. Where might you be tempted to treat God's mercy as indifference to sin, when verse 8 holds forgiveness and justice together?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).